3.4 Women in the Early Republic

To people living in the 21st century, the saying "a woman's place is in the home" is not only dated, it's inaccurate. However, in the early years of the republic, home was considered the ideal sphere for a woman's power and influence.

MAIN IDEA Increased access to education and the rise of women's organizations expanded women's roles in the early republic.

REPUBLICAN MOTHERHOOD

In the years after the Revolution, a strong nationalist spirit took hold as the young United States began to grow and prosper. Citizens embraced their new, republican government. As you have read, in the context of the early republic, the word *republican* did not refer to a political party, but to the new form of representative rule. Citizens also embraced the ideal of civic republicanism, or promoting the common good in order to protect liberty. According to the ideal of republicanism, good government and virtuous citizens worked toward the public good instead of private interests.

What did that mean for women in the early republic? Many had fully participated in the American Revolution, just as their husbands and sons had done. But after the war, women returned to their roles as wives and mothers. No matter their race or class, women were not allowed to vote or even, in many cases, to own their own property or hold public office. However, they participated in the republic by teaching republican ideals to their children—especially to their sons, who would grow up to be voters, property owners, and maybe even public officials or statesmen. Historians refer to this set of societal expectations for mothers as **republican motherhood**.



Mother as Teacher
The early 19th-century woman had a lot to live up to. Literature, art, and social expectations defined roles for women in narrow ways. Paintings such as this one cast women in a nearly angelic light and featured them as doting mothers.

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Catharine Beecher
In a family portrait taken around 1860, Catharine Beecher is seated second from the left. Beecher championed free public education for all and a rigorous education for women. However, her support of women's education did not extend to other rights for women. She opposed granting women the right to vote. She believed that women should limit their efforts to home and school and that a woman's greatest roles were those of wife and mother. Even so, she never married or had children, and she supported herself throughout her life as an educator, writer, and lecturer.

THE IMPORTANCE OF EDUCATION

In the early 1800s, the ideal woman was pure, religiously devout, and a good housekeeper and mother. She also willingly deferred to all her husband's wishes. Such a role did not require women to be well educated, and few learned more than language arts and basic arithmetic—subjects that aided them in running an efficient home. But without adequate education, how could mothers be expected to teach their children, especially their sons, the basics of civic life and service in a republic?

This question had been brewing since the American Revolution, when Abigail Adams argued that in order to support male education, women should be educated as well: "If we mean to have heroes, statesmen, and philosophers, we should have learned [educated] women."

A few years later, **Judith Sargent Murray,** an American essayist and playwright in the early republic, was known for commenting on public issues, especially women's rights. She wrote that women were not intellectually inferior to men, as some believed. She argued that daughters could not reach their full potential if they were simply trained to be wives, housekeepers, and mothers. In order to teach their children republican values, mothers needed to learn science and higher math, which were traditionally taught only to men.

In 1822, **Catharine Beecher** founded the Hartford Female Seminary, a school for women in Connecticut. Students learned algebra, Latin, logic, and philosophy, among other subjects. The curriculum emphasized physical education and training in home economics. Many women who attended became teachers themselves.

As more girls and women received formal educations, women began to establish organizations that focused on helping others. Many of the organizations had a specific focus, such as helping orphans, people with physical handicaps, or war widows. Members soon began to see the positive effects of their work. Women's organizations grew and expanded, and their leaders became important agents for social change. Some of these women's organizations also laid the groundwork for budding political and social movements, such as securing the vote for women and the **abolition** of, or putting an end to, slavery.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How does the concept of republican motherhood align with the ideals women were expected to live up to in the early republic?
2. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** What conclusions can you draw about the work that 19th-century women's organizations did?
3. **MAKE CONNECTIONS** How might a more comprehensive education and the expectation of rearing good citizens lead women to seek broader civic roles for themselves?

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